Conclusion
Looking Ahead: Perceptions, Perimeters, Partnerships, and Power

The crisis in Ladakh in the summer of 2020 showed how quickly India–China differences can turn violent. Indian analysts are still trying to understand why Chinese troops moved into areas in Ladakh, particularly in the Galwan area, that have been peaceful since 1962. Was the crisis triggered by Chinese *perceptions* that a series of Indian policies were attempts by an 'inferior' power to embarrass China, including Amit Shah's remarks on Aksai Chin, Delhi's criticism of Chinese connectivity projects, and India's tough military posture during the Doklam confrontation? Was it due to continuing differences over *perimeters* and Chinese worries over Indian infrastructure expansion? Was it, instead, Beijing's response to Delhi's increasing strategic *partnership* with Washington? Or, finally, was it a demonstration of *power* in consonance with China's growing assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific with Taiwan, Japan, Southeast Asia, and Australia, part of its 'wolf warrior' diplomacy? It is too early to tell conclusively, but as the earlier chapters have suggested, India–China relations always seem to be framed by a combination of these four elements. What is the future of mutual perceptions, differences over perimeters, rival partnerships, and the power gap? Does the future look positive or negative?

Perceptions, Perimeters, and Partnerships